

■ Familiarity Bias

■ What is it?

Favouring what we already know or recognize.

People naturally stick to familiar choices because they feel safe and comfortable—even if new options might be better.

For example, you might always order the same meal at KFC instead of trying something new.

■■ History

Familiarity bias is deeply connected to the **mere exposure effect**, first studied by psychologist **Robert Zajonc (1968)**.

He found that people tend to like things simply because they've been exposed to them repeatedly.

This also connects to the marketing **“Rule of 7”**—customers often need to see or hear a message multiple times before trusting or buying.

■ The Psychology Behind It

- Familiar things = **comfort and trust**.
- The brain saves energy by choosing what it already knows.
- Repetition builds loyalty but can also limit curiosity.

In UX and product design, this explains why people may avoid new features or stick to old habits, even when improvements are available.

■■ Why It Matters

Familiarity bias can lead to:

- Higher brand loyalty
- Stronger trust in known products
- Lower adoption of new products
- Missed opportunities for discovery

- Reduced overall engagement if users never explore further

■ How to Apply It

- **Highlight familiar elements** → keep design patterns consistent.
- **Use repeated exposure** → retargeting ads, multiple campaign touchpoints.
- **Build trust** → showcase testimonials, reviews, or endorsements.
- **Educate users** → guide them through new features with simple tutorials.
- **Encourage exploration** → “related items” displays or recommendations.

■ Theory in Action

- **Spotify** suggests songs and playlists based on what users already like, building on familiarity.
- **Grocery stores** place similar products together (e.g., chips of different brands) so shoppers feel safe trying alternatives.

■ Final Thought

Familiarity bias builds trust and loyalty—but it can also keep people stuck in routines.

Good design balances **comfort with curiosity**: give users familiar anchors while nudging them toward new and exciting experiences.